Burnes wrote that he had heard that in his youth Dost Mohammad had been wild and dissolute, but had become a reformed man now he had gained power. He had given up wine, taught himself to read and write, and affected piety and a simplicity of manner and dress. He was available to all, and anyone could come and ask for justice. Nor was it just that Burnes thought Dost Mohammad was personally impressive. He also saw him clearly as Britain's best bet for attaining influence in Afghanistan. As far as he was concerned the Sadozais had had their day, and as Dost Mohammad was so well disposed towards the British it would be possible to form an alliance with 'no great expenditure of public funds'.[76]

This was a radically different strategy to the one Wade had been suggesting to Calcutta, and it left Wade with two options: either to accept the opinion of the younger man who had spent little time in the region, but unlike him had now seen Kabul for himself; or to stand on his authority as the regional expert of twenty years and to continue to back Shah Shuja as Britain's best asset. He chose the latter course. 'The people are tired of wars and factions,' he wrote in May 1832, while Burnes was still in Kabul. 'They look for the reestablishment of their former [Sadozai] government as the only chance which presents itself of ensuring tranquillity.'[77] This was at variance with everything Burnes was reporting from the ground; but Wade made his case in exactly the way he knew would win the argument in Calcutta. He waited for Burnes to head on north from Kabul, where he was to reconnoitre the unmapped routes over the Hindu Kush, and then he made his move.

Wade was assisted by events in western Afghanistan, where the last bastion of Sadozai rule in Herat was about to be besieged by the Persians. Since the British had failed to come to the assistance of the Persians in the 1826–7 Russo-Persian War, the Persians had concluded that it was wiser to hug their Russian enemy close than entertain any further flirtations with the British who had proved unwilling to risk outright war with Russia in their support. Now the Persians were planning a campaign to retake Herat, and the hawks in Calcutta strongly suspected that this was really a Russian initiative in Persian disguise, part of an old Tsarist plan to set up a forward base in Afghanistan: an article inserted into a treaty signed five years earlier had given St Petersburg the right to set up a consulate in Herat if the Persians were ever to capture it. These fears were in reality erroneous – in 1832 the Russians were actually trying to dissuade the Persian Crown